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ARTICLE ANALYSIS

Comprehensive Study Guide, Vocabulary Builder & RC

Emperor Penguins on the Brink

Original Article

Emperor penguins are on the march — toward **extinction**

By Carolyn Gramling | Published May 8, 2026

Emperor penguins **brave** extreme cold, storms, **starvation**, and **predation**. But global warming might ultimately **defeat** their efforts. If populations of this species fall, these iconic birds might soon find themselves marching toward extinction.

Emperors are the largest of the penguins. On April 9, the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) moved the status of this species from "near threatened" to "critically endangered."

The IUCN is a network of more than 17,000 scientists and experts from over 160 countries who maintain the Red List. It identifies species that appear at risk of extinction in the wild — and how **imminent** their die-off might be. "Critically endangered" is the Red List's most severe category, meaning the species is at a "very high risk of extinction in the wild."

On Thin Ice

The breakup and loss of sea ice around Antarctica is driving emperor penguins toward the brink. Over the last decade, Antarctica has seen record lows in the expanse of sea ice that **fringes** the continent, and the breakup of that ice is happening earlier in the year.

This **imperils** the emperors. To breed and raise their young, this species requires "fast" ice — sea ice that is immobile most of the year. If this ice breaks apart too soon, emperor chicks risk drowning or freezing to death because the young birds do not yet have waterproof feathers.

In 2022, satellites observed a **catastrophic** loss of five separate emperor penguin colonies near the Bellingshausen Sea when the ice beneath them broke apart. In all, an estimated 10,000 chicks died.

Today, emperor penguin populations are estimated at around 595,000 adults, which is 10 to 22 percent fewer than in 2009. By 2080, the IUCN reports that the species' numbers are expected to fall by half.

"The emperor penguin's move to endangered is a **stark** warning," says Martin Harper, head of BirdLife International, the group that led the new assessment. "Climate change is **accelerating** [their] extinction crisis before our eyes."

Not Just Penguins: Antarctic Fur Seals

A loss of sea ice is also rapidly moving the Antarctic fur seal several steps closer to extinction, the IUCN reports.

In 1999, the animals were considered of "least concern" on the Red List, with an estimated 2.2 million adults. By 2025, that number had **plunged** to 944,000. This **dramatic** drop moved the seals' status to endangered.

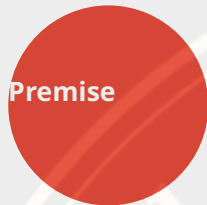
Climate change is playing a big role in this **decline** as well. Rising ocean temperatures and the loss of sea ice are pushing their primary food source — tiny crustaceans called krill — to deeper ocean depths. As a result, seal pups are far less likely to **survive** their first year.

Article Summary

Emperor penguins, the largest of their kind, have been reclassified as "critically endangered" by the IUCN due to the severe impacts of global warming. The premature breakup of immobile "fast" ice in Antarctica exposes young chicks, lacking waterproof feathers, to freezing waters, leading to massive casualties (e.g., 10,000 chicks lost in 2022). Consequently, their population is projected to halve by 2080. Concurrently, the Antarctic fur seal has also seen its status downgraded to "endangered" as rising temperatures force

krill—their primary food source—deeper into the ocean, drastically reducing pup survival rates.

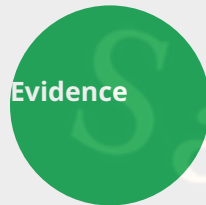
Article Anatomy



Species Crisis



Climate Change



Population Drops



Future Extinction



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15 Important Vocabulary Words

Word	POS	Meaning (Eng & Hindi)	Synonyms (5)	Antonyms (5)
Extinction	Noun	The state of ceasing to exist. (विलुप्ति)	Destruction, Annihilation, Eradication, Obliteration, Elimination	Survival, Existence, Creation, Continuation, Preservation
Brave	Verb	Endure unpleasant conditions. (सामना करना)	Endure, Face, Confront, Withstand, Weather	Avoid, Surrender, Flee, Capitulate, Retreat
Starvation	Noun	Suffering caused by hunger. (भुखमरी)	Famine, Malnutrition, Undernourishment, Fasting, Deprivation	Plenty, Abundance, Feast, Surfeit, Nourishment
Predation	Noun	Preying of one animal on others. (परभक्षण / शिकार)	Hunting, Plundering, Ravaging, Pillaging, Depredation	Protection, Guarding, Defense, Nurturing, Conservation
Defeat	Verb	Win a victory over. (हराना)	Conquer, Beat, Vanquish, Crush, Overpower	Surrender, Lose, Yield, Submit, Capitulate
Imminent	Adj	About to happen. (आसन्न / करीब)	Impending, Approaching, Looming, Forthcoming, Near	Distant, Remote, Delayed, Far-off, Unlikely
Imperil	Verb	Put at risk of harm. (खतरे में डालना)	Endanger, Jeopardize, Risk, Compromise, Threaten	Protect, Safeguard, Secure, Defend, Shield
Catastrophic	Adj	Causing sudden damage. (विनाशकारी)	Disastrous, Devastating, Ruinous, Tragic, Fatal	Beneficial, Fortunate, Blessed, Successful, Advantageous

Accelerate	Verb	Happen faster. (गति बढ़ाना)	Quicken, Hasten, Speed, Expedite, Advance	Delay, Decelerate, Hinder, Retard, Slow
Stark	Adj	Severe or bare in appearance. (कठोर / स्पष्ट)	Harsh, Bleak, Severe, Plain, Blunt	Mild, Cheerful, Pleasant, Fuzzy, Obscured
Plunge	Verb	Fall suddenly. (गिरना / डूबना)	Plummet, Dive, Drop, Tumble, Descend	Rise, Ascend, Soar, Climb, Surge
Dramatic	Adj	Sudden and striking. (नाटकीय)	Striking, Significant, Noticeable, Spectacular, Considerable	Ordinary, Normal, Commonplace, Subtle, Mild
Decline	Noun	Gradual loss of numbers/ strength. (गिरावट / पतन)	Decrease, Reduction, Drop, Slump, Downturn	Increase, Rise, Growth, Improvement, Ascent
Fringes	Verb	Form a border around. (किनारे होना)	Border, Edge, Surround, Enclose, Outline	Center, Interior, Inside, Middle, Core
Survive	Verb	Continue to live. (जीवित रहना)	Endure, Outlast, Persist, Outlive, Withstand	Perish, Succumb, Die, Expire, Cease

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Another Important Parts of Speech

Word	Parts of Speech	Reason / Context in Article
Breakup	Noun	Refers to the physical event of the ice breaking apart.
Critically	Adverb	Modifies the adjective "endangered" to show severity.
Separate	Adjective	Describes the distinct penguin colonies that were lost.
Rapidly	Adverb	Modifies the verb "moving," showing the speed of endangerment.
Deeper	Adjective (Comparative)	Describes the increased depth of the ocean waters krill retreat to.

Important Parts of Speech Overview

In this article, **Nouns** function as the primary subjects (e.g., "Emperor penguins", "sea ice", "krill"), carrying the core scientific and ecological data. **Verbs** describe critical actions or states (e.g., "brave", "imperils", "plunged"), driving the narrative of population decline. **Adjectives** heavily modify the tone, adding a sense of urgency and despair (e.g., "catastrophic", "stark", "imminent"). **Adverbs** like "ultimately" and "rapidly" modify the timeline of the impending crisis.

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Idioms and Phrases

- **"On the march"**

Meaning: Making steady progress or advancing.

Example: The enemy forces are on the march toward the capital. (In the text, penguins are ironically 'advancing' toward extinction.)

- **"Toward the brink"**

Meaning: Moving very close to a disastrous or extreme situation.

Example: The company's risky investments pushed it toward the brink of bankruptcy.

- **"Before our eyes"**

Meaning: Happening while one is watching; directly in front of someone.

Example: The glacier is melting right before our eyes.



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Practice Set: Fill in the Blanks

Choose the best synonym from the options to fill in the blank based on the context of the article.

1. The soldiers had to _____ the harsh winter conditions without adequate supplies.

- A) succumb
- B) weather
- C) capitulate
- D) yield
- E) surrender

2. The extinction of the fragile species is _____, according to the latest scientific models.

- A) distant
- B) unlikely
- C) impending
- D) remote
- E) delayed

3. Satellites observed a _____ loss of habitats along the coastline after the hurricane.

- A) disastrous
- B) beneficial
- C) fortunate
- D) mild
- E) insignificant

4. Human interference in the forest is _____ the destruction of the ecosystem.

- A) delaying
- B) hindering
- C) retarding
- D) hastening
- E) slowing

5. The number of active fur seals has _____ heavily since the turn of the century.

- A) surged
- B) soared
- C) climbed
- D) ascended
- E) plummeted

Practice Set: Error Detection

Identify the part of the sentence containing a grammatical error. If there is no error, select option (E).

6. The breakup and loss (A) / of sea ice around Antarctica (B) / is driving emperor penguins (C) / towards the brinks. (D) / No Error (E)

- A) A B) B C) C D) D E) E

7. The IUCN are a network (A) / of more than 17,000 scientists (B) / and experts from over (C) / 160 countries who maintain the Red List. (D) / No Error (E)

- A) A B) B C) C D) D E) E

8. Emperor chicks risk drowning (A) / or freezing to death (B) / because the young birds (C) / do not yet has waterproof feathers. (D) / No Error (E)

- A) A B) B C) C D) D E) E

9. By 2080, the IUCN reports (A) / that the species' numbers (B) / is expected to fall (C) / by half. (D) / No Error (E)

- A) A B) B C) C D) D E) E

10. Rising ocean temperatures (A) / and the loss of sea ice (B) / are pushing their primary food source (C) / to deeper ocean depths. (D) / No Error (E)

- A) A B) B C) C D) D E) E

Practice Set: Reading Comprehension

The survival of Emperor penguins is heavily dependent on "fast" ice, a type of sea ice that remains firmly attached to the coastline and stable for most of the year. This stable ice shelf is absolutely crucial for the birds to breed and raise their chicks safely away from marine predators. However, steadily rising global temperatures have led to an early and unpredictable breakup of this sea ice. This early fragmentation exposes the highly vulnerable chicks to freezing ocean waters long before they can develop their mature, waterproof feathers, ultimately resulting in massive casualties, such as the estimated loss of 10,000 chicks in the Bellingshausen Sea in 2022.

Beyond the plight of the penguins, the Antarctic fur seal is experiencing a parallel ecological nightmare. The warming ocean waters have fundamentally altered the marine food web. Krill, the tiny crustaceans that serve as the seals' primary food source, are sensitive to warm water and have been forced to migrate to deeper, colder depths. Consequently, the lack of easily accessible food in the shallow layers has drastically reduced the survival rates of seal pups. This nutritional deficit has caused the seal population to plummet significantly, prompting international conservation bodies to change their status to endangered.

11. What is the primary reason for the high mortality rate among Emperor penguin chicks mentioned in the passage?

- A) Increased predation by other marine animals in the shallow waters.
- B) Premature melting of fast ice exposing them to freezing waters.
- C) A severe lack of krill in the shallow ocean waters.
- D) Inability of adult penguins to find secure breeding grounds.
- E) An unknown disease spreading rapidly through the colonies.

12. How does the migration of krill affect the Antarctic fur seal population?

- A) It forces the adult seals to migrate to warmer oceanic regions.
- B) It causes seal pups to starve due to inaccessible deep-water food sources.
- C) It encourages the seals to hunt for alternative prey along the coast.
- D) It leads to an overpopulation of adult seals competing in deep waters.
- E) It has no significant long-term impact on the seal pup survival rate.

13. What critical role does "fast" ice play in the life cycle of Emperor penguins?

- A) It provides a moving platform for hunting deep-sea fish.
- B) It acts as a permanent physical barrier against natural predators.
- C) It offers a stable environment required for breeding and rearing chicks.
- D) It regulates the ocean temperature immediately around the continent.
- E) It serves as the primary source of fresh drinking water for the colonies.

14. Which of the following best describes the tone of the passage?

- A) Optimistic and encouraging about future conservation efforts.
- B) Informative and alarming regarding the impact of climate change.
- C) Satirical and highly critical of the scientific community's findings.
- D) Nostalgic and deeply reflective on past environmental conditions.
- E) Indifferent and strictly objective without any underlying concern.

15. According to the passage, what specific consequence did the warming ocean waters have on krill?

- A) They multiplied rapidly due to the warmer temperatures at the surface.
- B) They moved to shallower waters to escape the changing currents.
- C) They were driven to deeper, colder depths within the ocean.
- D) They evolved to consume a different type of deep-sea plankton.
- E) They became highly toxic to the animals that naturally consumed them.

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Answer Key & Explanations

Fill in the Blanks

- 1. Answer: B) weather.** Explanation: "Brave" in the context of the article means to endure or withstand harsh conditions. "Weather" is the best synonym among the options.
- 2. Answer: C) impending.** Explanation: "Imminent" means about to happen. "Impending" accurately reflects the looming nature of the extinction.
- 3. Answer: A) disastrous.** Explanation: "Catastrophic" implies sudden, great damage. "Disastrous" is a direct synonym.
- 4. Answer: D) hastening.** Explanation: "Accelerating" means speeding up a process. "Hastening" captures this meaning perfectly.
- 5. Answer: E) plummeted.** Explanation: "Plunged" refers to a rapid fall or drop. "Plummeted" is the exact synonym for a sudden drop in population.

Error Detection

- 6. Answer: D.** Explanation: The idiom is "towards the brink", not "brinks" (plural). "Brink" acts as an uncountable concept here.
- 7. Answer: A.** Explanation: The IUCN is a singular entity (an organization), so the verb should be "is", not "are". (The IUCN is a network...)
- 8. Answer: D.** Explanation: The subject "young birds" is plural, so the verb must be plural: "do not yet HAVE waterproof feathers", not "has".
- 9. Answer: C.** Explanation: The subject of the clause is "numbers" (plural), so the verb should be plural: "ARE expected to fall", not "is".
- 10. Answer: E.** Explanation: The sentence is grammatically correct. Subjects and verbs agree, and modifiers are properly placed.

Reading Comprehension

11. Answer: B. Explanation: The first paragraph clearly states that early fragmentation of fast ice exposes vulnerable chicks to freezing ocean waters before their waterproof feathers develop.

12. Answer: B. Explanation: Paragraph 2 explains that krill migrated to deeper depths, creating a lack of easily accessible food in shallow layers, which reduced the survival rates of pups (starvation).

13. Answer: C. Explanation: The passage states that fast ice remains attached to the coastline and stable, which is "crucial for the birds to breed and raise their chicks safely".

14. Answer: B. Explanation: The author presents factual data ("estimated loss of 10,000 chicks") while expressing serious concern ("massive casualties", "ecological nightmare"), making the tone informative and alarming.

15. Answer: C. Explanation: The text explicitly mentions that krill are sensitive to warm water and have been "forced to migrate to deeper, colder depths."

"Education is the passport to the future, for tomorrow belongs to those who prepare for it today." – Malcolm X

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